The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

America is reportedly sending at least 2,200 more **marines** and three warships to the Middle East; more than 50,000 American troops are already in the region. Earlier Donald Trump called NATO members "cowards" for refusing to help America to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. **Iran** pledged to expand attacks on the Gulf's energy infrastructure, following strikes against Bahrain, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates on Friday.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, topped $110 a barrel before falling on Friday as speculation mounted of an American operation on **Kharg Island**, the site of Iran's main oil terminal. Meanwhile **Spain** announced a €5bn ($5.7bn) emergency package to mitigate disruption from the war, including plans to cut value-added tax on electricity and natural gas from 21% to 10%.

The **International Energy Agency**, an intergovernmental organisation, is recommending that people **work from home** as an emergency response to the "largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market". It also suggests car sharing and avoiding air travel. The IEA warns that the economic impact of the war in Iran could grow "more and more severe".

France's president, **Emmanuel Macron**, said his country's navy seized a tanker in the Mediterranean sailing under a false flag as part of **Russia's** shadow fleet. The vessel was flying a Mozambican flag after departing from Russia. The operation was a joint effort involving British forces. In a statement Mr Macron said the war in Iran would not "deflect France from its support for Ukraine".

Colombia's president, **Gustavo Petro**, is being investigated by American criminal prosecutors over alleged connections to drug traffickers, according to media reports. The drug probe apparently spans wider than Mr Petro; an unnamed source told Reuters that it was not "squarely focused on him". Mr Trump has previously called Mr Petro an "illegal drug trafficker", an accusation he denies.

Unilever, a consumer goods conglomerate, is in talks to sell its food business to **McCormick & Company**, a spice and seasoning giant. The discussions are part of a pivot towards its faster-growing beauty and personal care brands. The company's food division, which includes brands such as Marmite, Knorr, and Hellmann's, is worth anywhere from €28bn ($32bn) to €31bn, according to estimates by Barclays, a bank.

Chuck Norris died at the age of 86. The martial-arts star had his cinema debut alongside Bruce Lee in "The Way of the Dragon" in 1972; he later acted in the TV series "Walker, Texas Ranger". His popularity took off again in the 2000s with Chuck Norris facts, deadpan memes about his exaggerated toughness. Tributes came from fellow actors Sylvester Stallone and Jean-Claude Van Damme.

Figure of the day: 7.2%, the amount by which Cuba's GDP is forecast to shrink in 2026. Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

Iranians' unhappy new year

In Iran, this weekend should have been festive. Unusually, the spring festival of Nowruz coincides with Eid, which marks the end of Ramadan. Iranians would normally flock to seaside resorts or picnic in the mountains. Instead, many are sheltering in stairwells, worn down by three weeks of bombardment. America claims to have struck 7,000 targets; Israel thousands more. More than 3,000 Iranians have been killed, including at least 1,300 civilians, according to HRANA, a human-rights group.

But America and Israel have not succeeded in triggering their promised popular uprising. America appears to have stepped back from its initial pursuit of regime change. However, Israel and Reza Pahlavi, the former Shah's son, continue to urge Iranians to take to the streets, most recently for this week's fire festival, ahead of Nowruz. So far their calls have not been answered. Instead Israel created fireworks by bombing the South Pars gas field, which supplies much of Iran's fuel.

Photograph: Reuters

A spying scandal hangs over Slovenia's election

As Friday ends Slovenia will plunge into electoral silence ahead of its vote on Sunday. The final week of campaigning has been anything but quiet. Local media alleged that Janez Jansa (pictured), the populist opposition leader, met with operatives from Black Cube, an Israeli political-intelligence firm. Their report suggests Black Cube published footage earlier this month that appeared to implicate several people connected to the government in corruption. Those captured in the videos deny wrongdoing; Black Cube did not respond to our request for comment.

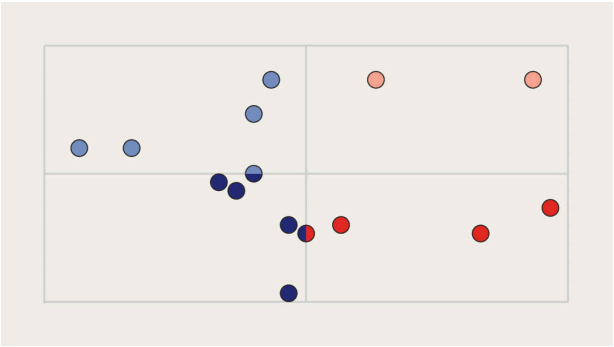
Mr Jansa, a three-time prime minister and an ally of Viktor Orban, Hungary's strongman, denies being part of a plot, but says the footage shows the government is crooked. His party praised Black Cube for purportedly exposing graft. Robert Golob, the liberal prime minister, has warned of foreign interference. Slovenia's election may now hinge on whether voters are more concerned by what the videos revealed, or by who made them.

Photograph: AP

Excitement and anxiety at BTS's return

The world's biggest boyband is back. BTS released their long-anticipated new album on Friday. In 2019 the K-pop act became the first band since the Beatles to have three chart-topping albums in under a year. But in 2022 the group—whose full name translates as "Bulletproof Boy Scouts"—took a break to complete their mandatory military service. Some 260,000 fans, many from abroad, are expected to attend their free comeback concert in Seoul on Saturday. It will also be live-streamed on Netflix.

Such a popular event will benefit the local economy. Yet Koreans are jittery about the arrival of the ARMY (as the group's global fans are known). The city is still haunted by the deadly crowd crush which killed more than 150 Halloween revellers in 2022. Officials are closing roads, rerouting public transport, shutting nearby attractions and dispatching thousands of police around Saturday's show. The capital is determined to have only happy memories of BTS's return.



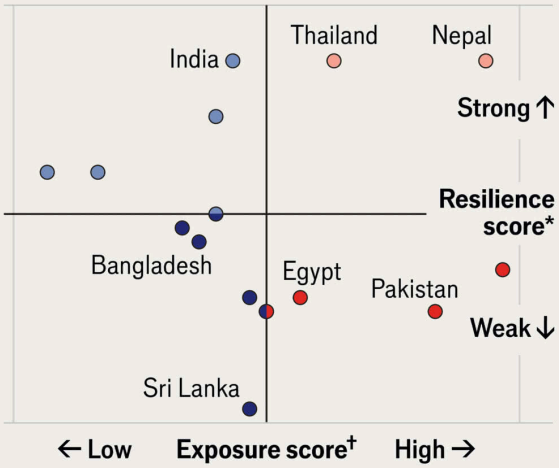
Photograph:

Data bite: Who will expensive energy hurt most?

Some emerging economies are more vulnerable to global energy shocks than others. To judge which are likely to suffer most from the current crisis, we measured countries' reliance on imported energy and on aid and remittances from the Gulf. We also sized up their foreign-exchange reserves. Pakistan and Egypt are in trouble: both import a lot of oil and gas; their stock of foreign exchange is low. Better off are two other big energy importers: Nepal, which has plenty of hard currency, and Thailand, which has large oil reserves. Bangladesh and Sri Lanka rely less on energy imports, but their foreign-currency cushions are thin. Read our analysis.

The insulated and the isolated

Emerging markets, exposure and resilience to Iran war oil shock, 2024 or latest



*Based on foreign-exchange reserves & external government debt †Based on net oil & gas imports, oil & gas imports from the Middle East & Gulf remittances
Sources: UN; World Bank; IMF; national statistics; *The Economist*

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which 1950 novel by Ray Bradbury is set on another planet?

Thursday: What word is used for a demand that must be met within a set period of time?

The spirit of truth and the spirit of freedom—these are the pillars of society.

Henrik Ibsen